CHAPTER SECOND

The Beginning & The Dream

: The Beginning

She steps closer, concern evident in her blue eyes, she is around the same age as him, wearing a half pant and T-shirt in black, with a softness in her demeanor that contrasts with his troubled state. She moves to stand beside him, glancing out the window before looking back at him.
"Again? right?" She said softly.
"What did you see this time? Ayaan"

Ayaan closes his eyes for a moment, as if trying to push away the haunting images in his mind, but they come flooding back. His voice is shaky as he begins to explain.
"They Died." He takes a deep breath and continue.
“It was the same couple... The woman... she was pregnant.”
Tears were flowing from his eyes as if he himself was feeling the pain. He continues -
"They were on a train. Everything seemed normal at first, but then... the train derailed. I could see it all happening so clearly-the screeching metal, the screams, the bodies..... The burning bodies..... and also.....a burned child ....."

He pauses, his hands gripping the window tightly as he continues, his voice thick with emotion.
"I keep seeing them. The same couple, But this accident, it's the first time I saw something like this. Its feels more real then other dreams Like I'm there, watching them. Helplessly."
She reaches out, placing a gentle hand on Ayaan's arm. Her voice is soft, but firm, trying to anchor him in the present.

"Ayaan, it's just a dream. I know it feels real, but it's not. You don't have to worry about it.
Ayaan turns to face her, his eyes searching hers for some kind of answer, but finding none. He lets out a frustrated breath, his shoulde slumping slightly.

"I don't know Tanya. I just... I feel like I'm losing control. Like this dream is slowly taking over my mind. I'm scared to close my eyes because I know they'll be there, waiting for me."

After listening to this she got chills through her spins her eyes widen slightly, but she quickly composes herself and walks closer to Ayaan, her steps deliberate and calm.
Tanya by forcing a smile
"Ayaan, dreams can be strange, can't they? They don't mean anything, you know that, right? It's just your mind playing tricks."
Ayaan, looking down, his voice quiet

"But it feels so real. It's like... like I know them, like they're trying to tell me something. Why do I keep seeing them?"
Tanya watches as the fear slowly fades from Ayaan's eyes, but she knows it's not enough to just distract him with talk of writing. She needs to shift his focus entirely, to give him something else to think about, something that would occupy his mind. Tanya keeps her tone light, but her words are deliberate as she moves the conversation further away from the disturbing dream.

Tanya, gently:
"Ayaan, you should really try to get some rest. We've got a big day ahead of us, remember? You wanted to attend that lecture by the neuropsychologist at the town hall today, right? It's at 10:00 a.m., and you've been looking forward to it for weeks."

Ayaan blinks, the mention of the lecture momentarily prilling him out of his trobled thoughts. He'd been eager to attend the lecture fascinated by the working of the human mind. Tanya's mention of it serves as a subtle nudge, reminding him of something he's genuinely interested in.
"Yeah, I remember. I wanted to ask about these dreams.....maybe they can help me understand why I keep having them."

Tanya nods, her expression encouraging, even though her heart aches knowing something behind his nightmares.
"Exactly you can ask them all about it. They're experts, and who knows? Maybe they'll have some answers that will help you to make sense of everything. Plus, we've got to prepare for our new school, which opens from the Monday. You'll have new friends to meet, and I'm sure once your mind is busy with school and new people, these dreams will start to fade away. "
Ayaan's gaze drops to the floor, his earlier enthusiasm for the lecture replaced by a sullen expression. His voice is low, almost defeated, as he responds.

"New friends. I didn't have any friends in my old school. I don't think I need them. Nobody wants me to be as a friend, anyway. I have nothing exciting to talk about... I'm nothing."
Tanya feels a pang of sorrow at his words. She steps closer, her voice firm yet tender as she tries to pull him out of the dark place his mind is drifting toward.
"Oye! that's not true. You're one of the most interesting people I know. You're smart, curious, and you care about things most people don't even notice. That makes you special, even if you don't see it right now. And about friends... sometimes it just takes time to find the right ones. But they're out there, trust me."

Ayaan looks up at her, his eyes searching hers for some reassurance, something to hold onto. Tanya offers a small, warm smile, trying to convey the belief he so desperately needs. She sees the tiredness in his eyes, and she knows he needs rest more than anything right now.
"But right now, what you need is sleep. The sun's not even fully up yet. Let's get you back to bed, and we can talk more in the morning. We'll go to that lecture, and who knows, maybe you'll find something new to be excited about. Everything will seem clearer after you've had some rest."
Ayaan hesitates, then nods slowly, the weight of his exhaustion finally catching up to him. Tanya gently guides him back to his bed, pulling the covers over him as he settles in. She smooths the hair away from his forehead, her touch comforting and familiar.
"I'll be right here, okay? You're not alone."

Ayaan closes his eyes, the tension in his body easing as he listens to Tanya's calming voice. The room is quiet, the soft ticking of the clock the only sound. Slowly, his breathing evens out, and Tanya watches as he drifts off to sleep, his troubled expression finally relaxing. Then Tanya's attention was drawn to his green pendant, which—for some reason she couldn't quite fathom today—looked incredibly deep.
She stays by his side for a while, making sure he's truly asleep. The early morning light filters softly through the curtains, casting a gentle glow over the room. Tanya's heart is heavy with the knowledge she's keeping from him, but for now, she's done what she can. She'll face the rest when the time comes.
Tanya quietly leaves the room, closing the door behind her with a soft click. The house is still the world outside peaceful, but the storm within her heart continues to rage as she walks away.

PART 2 : The Beginning

At 9:23 Am Ayaan and Tanya leave for attending the lecture.

Ayaan and Tanya walk side by side through the bustling streets, the sun shining brightly above. The clear weather has brought people out in droves, and the energy of the city contrasts with the lingering heaviness in Ayaan's mind. The town hall is just a few blocks away, but the walk feels longer than usual, stretched out by the thoughts swirling in Ayaan's head. Tanya, sensing his unease, tries to keep the conversation light as they make their way to the lecture.
Tanya, glancing at Ayaan: "It's a beautiful day, isn't it? Hard to believe it was pouring just yesterday."
Ayaan nods absentmindedly, his hands tucked into his pockets. His mind is elsewhere, still caught in the grip of the dream that haunted his sleep.
" Yeah... it's nice."

Tanya notices his distant tone and decides to shift the conversation to something more engaging.
"So, what's the first thing you want to ask the neuropsychologist? I bet they'll have some really interesting answers. You've been reading up on psychology a lot lately, haven't you?"
Ayaan shrugs, still not fully present in the moment.
"I guess I want to know why people have recurring dreams. Why do certain images or people keep coming back, even when you don't want them to?"
Tanya nods, understanding the depth of Ayaan's curiosity, but also trying to steer him away from dwelling too much on his nightmares.

"That's a great question. Dreams are like puzzles, I suppose—pieces of our thoughts and feelings trying to fit together. But sometimes, it's just our minds playing tricks on us, showing us things that don't really mean anything."
Ayaan frowns slightly, the frustration bubbling up inside him.
"But it feels like it means something, Tanya. Like there's a reason I keep seeing that couple. Maybe it's not just a trick."

Tanya feels the tension rising again, and she decides to deflect gently, trying to keep the mood light and the conversation moving forward.
"Well, that's why we're going to this lecture, right? To figure out if there's something more to it or if it's just your imagination running wild. And hey, maybe after the lecture, we can grab some ice cream. There's that new place by the park that everyone's talking about."
Ayaan's expression softens a bit at the mention of ice cream, the idea of a treat momentarily distracting him from his darker thoughts.
"Ice cream sounds nice."

They continue walking, the town hall now visible at the end of the street. The closer they get, the more Ayaan starts to focus on the upcoming lecture, the prospect of getting answers both intriguing and daunting. As they approach the Entrance Tanya keeps the conversation flowing, hoping to keep Ayaan's mind from drifting back to his nightmares.
Tanya: "I'm sure the lecture will be fascinating. And who knows? You might even meet some people who share your interests. Maybe some future classmates?"

Ayaan sighs softly, his earlier doubts resurfacing.
Ayaan: "Maybe... but you know how it was at my old school. I'm not great at making friends. I always feel like I don't fit in."
Tanya stops for a moment, turning to face Ayaan directly. Her voice is firm but kind, trying to instill some confidence in him.
"Ayaan, fitting in isn't everything. You've got so much to offer—your curiosity, your intelligence, your kindness. If people can't see that, then they're the ones missing out, not you. Just be yourself, and the right people will come into your lie."
Ayaan looks at her, a small smile playing on his lips, though his eyes still hold a trace of uncertainty.
"Thanks, Sis. I'll try... but it's hard sometimes."

Tanya, smiling warmly,
"I know it is, but you're not alone in this. I'll be there with you, every step of the way. And who knows? Maybe this new school will be a fresh start for both of us."
Ayaan nods, feeling a bit more at ease as they reach the steps of the town hall. The large doors loom ahead, and the murmur of voices can be heard from within as people gather for the lecture. Tanya glances at her watch and then at Ayaan.

Then suddenly Nikita feels an unknown aura, it's not an ordinary one. Then a tall boy with brown hair sweeps back in loose, natural waves with revealing sharp amber eyes, collides with Ayaan, he looks tired as if he has come running from a long distance.

He said "I am sorry...are you hurt."
Ayaan: "No, it's ok.....are you feeling okay, you look tired'ed"
Tanya: "here, drink some water, take it."
" O, thanks."
After drinking water he walks away from there, by giving a calm smile.
Tanya: "Looks like we're right on time. Ready to go in?"

Ayaan takes a deep breath, his nerves still present but less overwhelming now, thanks to Tanya's support. He nods, his resolve strengthening.
"Yeah... let's go."
They walk up the steps together, entering the town hall where the lecture is about to begin. The large room is filled with people, all seated and waiting in anticipation.
That boy from the earlier steps slowed, his eyes narrowing as the memory of that earlier sensation resurfaced.
Boy: "That aura I felt before…"
He paused, his gaze locking firmly towards the stage.
"Is it really you ? Shubham Malhotra."

It sounds like the boy is addressing someone named "Shubham Malhotra", having just sensed a powerful aura. The boy seems genuinely surprised at the intensity of this power.

On the other side Tanya and Ayaan find their seats near the middle, the atmosphere buzzing with quiet excitement. As the neuropsychologist takes the stage and the lecture begins.

The stage lights dimmed, leaving a single spotlight bathing the polished wooden podium in a warm glow. Murmurs in the packed seminar hall hushed to silence as a tall man stepped onto the stage with an elegance that seemed almost rehearsed.

His long black hair was tied neatly at the back, but a few strands escaped, leaning forward over both eyes like a deep hypnotic black sharp orbs that seemed to pull you in.

The long professional coat he wore swayed with each step, and when he reached the center, he smiled warmly, the kind of smile that invited trust.

He adjusted the mic.

The lecture hall gradually settled into silence as the professor stepped onto the stage. The faint murmurs of hundreds of students slowly faded, replaced by an atmosphere of curiosity and anticipation.

"Good morning, everyone. My name is Dr. Shubham Malhotra," he said with a warm smile. "Today's lecture is about something every one of us experiences, yet very few truly understand. Dreams."

Ayaan adjusted himself in his seat and opened his notebook while Tanya sat quietly beside him, her attention fixed on the professor.

For the next several minutes, Dr. Malhotra guided the students through the scientific foundations of dreams. He spoke about REM sleep, memory processing, emotional regulation, and the way the human brain remains active even while the body rests.

His explanations were simple enough for newcomers to understand, yet detailed enough to keep the hall completely engaged.

Time passed.

Slides changed.

Questions appeared on the screen and disappeared again.

Students continued taking notes while Dr. Malhotra moved across the stage with the confidence of someone who had delivered this lecture countless times before.

"Many researchers believe dreams help us organize memories," he explained. "Think of your mind as a librarian sorting through thousands of books every day. Some memories are stored carefully. Others are discarded."

A few students chuckled softly.

The lecture continued.

Nearly half an hour had already passed when the topic slowly shifted from ordinary dreams to something far more intriguing.

"Not all dreams disappear when we wake up," Dr. Malhotra said, his tone becoming noticeably quieter. "Some remain with us. Some return again and again."

The hall gradually fell silent.

"Recurring dreams are fascinating because they often connect to unresolved emotions, forgotten experiences, or memories buried deep within the subconscious mind."

Ayaan's pen slowed.

For some reason, every word felt strangely familiar.

Dr. Malhotra stopped near the edge of the stage and looked across the audience.

"Imagine a dream so vivid that you can feel the wind, smell the rain, and remember every detail years later. Most people would dismiss it as imagination."

He paused.

"But what if it isn't?"

The silence deepened.

"What if it is a memory your conscious mind has forgotten?"

Ayaan's hand froze above the page.

The professor continued speaking, but now the lecture no longer felt like a lecture. It felt personal.

"The subconscious mind remembers far more than we realize. Sometimes it preserves events long after our waking mind chooses to bury them."

A strange tension settled in Ayaan's chest.

The dreams.

The voices.

The rain.

The shadows.

For years they had returned exactly the same way.

Beside him, Tanya noticed the change immediately. His grip around the pen had tightened. His shoulders had become rigid.

After another stretch of discussion and examples, the lecture slowly approached its conclusion.

Dr. Malhotra returned to the center of the stage and folded his hands behind his back.

"Dreams are more than random stories created by the mind," he said. "Sometimes they reveal our fears. Sometimes our desires. Sometimes our memories."

His gaze swept across the hall.

"And occasionally..."

A faint smile appeared on his face.

"...they reveal doors we never knew existed."

The spotlight reflected softly against the stage as he looked over the audience one final time.

"Dreams are keys. The real question is this..."

His voice echoed through the hall.

"What are they trying to unlock?"

For a moment, nobody spoke.

Then applause filled the room.

Students began clapping enthusiastically as the lecture came to an end.

Tanya joined them, but her attention remained on the person sitting beside her.

Ayaan did not clap.

He remained completely still, staring at the stage.

As though somewhere during the last hour, a door inside his mind had quietly begun to open.

From the back row the unknown boy leaned forward ever so slightly, a faint smrik tugging at his lips.

Dr. Malhotra steps away from the podium, prepared to answer questions from the eager attendees.

As the lecture ends, Ayaan and Tanya exchange a look, each of them reflecting on what they've just heard, the words resonating with the thoughts and worries they've both been carrying.

They sit quietly in their seats, waiting for the crowd to thin out as Dr. Malhotra patiently answers questions from the audience.

Ayaan fidgets nervously, his mind racing as he tries to form the right words to describe his recurring nightmare. Tanya sits beside him, offering silent support, sensing the tension in him as the room gradually empties. Finally, as the last person walks away, Dr. Malhotra looks up and notices the two young faces waiting hesitantly.

Dr. Malhotra: "Ah, I see we have a few more questions. Come on over." Ayaan and Tanya walk up to the front. Ayaan takes a deep breath before speaking, his voice steady but carrying an undercurrent of unease.

Ayaan: "Dr. Malhotra, I wanted to ask you about a dream I've been having... it keeps coming back, and it's always the same. I use to see a couple, a man and a pregnant woman. I've had this dream countless times now. Why do I keep seeing it? What does it mean?"

Dr. Malhotra's welcoming expression falters slightly, just for a brief moment, but enough for Tanya to notice. He quickly regains his composure, his tone measured and calm, yet there's a subtle tension beneath his words, He sense something off form them.

"Recurring dreams can sometimes point to unresolved emotions or deep-seated fears, Ayaan. It's possible that your mind is grappling with something you haven't fully processed, perhaps something from your past."

Ayaan's brow furrows, sensing that there's more to Dr. Malhotra's answer than what he's saying. Tanya, too, picks up on the slight shift in Dr. Malhotra's demeanor, her eyes narrowing as she watches the neuropsychologist closely.

Ayaan: "But... why this dream? Why them? I don't know these people. Why does it feel so real, like it's more than just a dream?"

Dr. Malhotra with a cold look, his gaze briefly flicking to Tanya before returning to Ayaan.

He didn't focus on choosing his words, because something else has distracted him.

"Dreams often blend elements of reality with imagination. The mind can create vivid scenarios that feel real, but that doesn't necessarily mean they are. Sometimes, our brain connects us to things we might not consciously remember. But... perhaps this is something you should discuss further in a more private setting, Ayaan. It might help to talk in more detail with a professional who can explore these dreams with you."

Ayaan exchanges a glance with Tanya, both of them sensing that Dr. Malhotra is holding something back. The neuropsychologist's words, though carefully chosen, leave a lingering doubt in the air.
Ayaan, softly: "Okay... thank you, Dr. Malhotra."

Dr. Malhotra nods, offering a tight-lipped smile before turning his attention back to the next person. Ayaan and Tanya walk away, a cloud of unease hanging over them as they leave the town hall.

Tanya looks at Ayaan, her voice low and concerned.
"Is he…… for real?"
Ayaan, the dream still heavy on his mind, but now joined by a new sense of uncertainty.
Ayaan: "There's something he wasn't saying. But what, and why?"

They continue walking in silence, the mystery of Ayaan's dream now deepened by the cryptic response of Dr. Malhotra.
When they both came out of the town hall, the road was completely empty because perhaps the weather had already warned them about its coming dark clouds.

Then breaking through the slightly cold winds blowing before the storm.
A voice came.

"Tanya."

Both of them recognized it immediately.

Ayaan freezes, his heart skipping a beat. He turns quickly, his eyes wide with fear, because just a moment ago, they had left him inside the town hall. How could he be behind them now? The suddenness of the voice unnerves him deeply, but Tanya's reaction is different. Her expression hardens as she turns to face the source of the voice she stared at

Malhotra by a very cold look. She doesn't seem surprised-more like resigned.

And this was very suspicious for both of them because just a while ago they had seen Malhotra inside. Ayaan gets scared by the sudden voice but Tanya is not surprised now because this time she felt the aura coming out from inside Malhotra.
Ayaan: (scared) "T-Tanya... how did he...?"

Tanya doesn't answer immediately, her gaze fixed on Malhotra, who now stands in the shadow of a nearby building. The air around him feels different, charged with a strange energy that only Tanya seems to fully recognize.

Ayaan can sense something is wrong, but he can't quite place what it is. His fear deepens, but Tanya's cold, focused expression calms him somewhat, though it also confirms her suspicions.

Calm Malhotra with a hint of authority : "Tanya, I need to speak with you. Alone. It's about Ayaan's dreams-there's something I can't discuss in front of him."

Ayaan looks at Tanya, confused and worried. He doesn't want her to go, but something in Malhotra's tone makes it clear that this is not a request. Tanya glances at Ayaan, her eyes softening slightly as she reassures him with a nod.
"Stay here, Ayaan. I'll be back soon."

Ayaan hesitates but nods reluctantly, his anxiety palpable. Tanya turns and follows Malhotra, who leads her to his office within the town hall. The corridors are eerily silent as they walk, the only sound being their footsteps.

When they reach his office, Malhotra opens the door and gestures for Tanya to enter. Once inside, he closes the door behind them, the atmosphere heavy with unspoken tension.

Malhotra, voice low, almost conspiratorial: "You sense it now, don't you? Am I right?"

Tanya's eyes narrow, her expression cold and unyielding. She knows exactly what he's referring to, the aura that surrounded him when he appeared behind them outside and the most important,

his **Soul Resonance** .

"It's enough, Malhotra. What are you really after?"

Dr. Malhotra's face tightens slightly, a flash of frustration crossing his features. He knows that Tanya is not easily intimidated, and her response only confirms that she's more aware than he initially thought.
"Okay, So tell me, Do you know anything about the last incident at the downtown area?"

Tanya meets his gaze without flinching, her eyes cold and calculating. She knows this conversation is about more than just Ayaan's dreams. There's something much bigger at play, something dark that ties them all together. The mention of the downtown incident sends a chill through her, but she refuses to show any sign of weakness.

The room falls into a tense silence, the air thick with the weight of unsaid words and hidden agendas. Dr. Malhotra watches Tanya closely, but she doesn't waver, her cold gaze fixed on him.
The scene fades out with Tanya's piercing eyes locked onto Dr. Malhotra, a silent battle of wills unfolding between them as the shadows of their secrets loom large.

Behind Every Face Lies An ocean
And we mistake it
For a puddel.

END CHAPTER: II